

Lecture XI - Arena Seat Planning under Distancing Rules

Applied Optimization with Julia

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Introduction

Covid-19 Pandemic

Challenges for Live Events

- Overall number of participants at events **was restricted**
- Certain **spacing between participants** had to be ensured
- Larger events required **vaccination certificates** for all

...

Question: **What are the main issues for the organizers?**

Main Difficulties

- Organization of larger events **is costly**
- Even without a pandemic a **financial risk**
- **Administrative Burden** for vaccination certificates
- Reduced capacity is a **loss of revenue**
- Implementing and enforcing **distancing rules**
- Managing **different priorities** of groups

Idea: Optimizing Seating Plans

Background

- **Applications:** sport arenas, concert halls, movie theaters, lecture halls, etc.
- People from the same group are **seated together**
- Venues have **specific seating**, season tickets, VIPs, etc.

...

! Important

Optimizing seating plans can help to **maximize revenue** while ensuring distancing rules and other constraints are met.

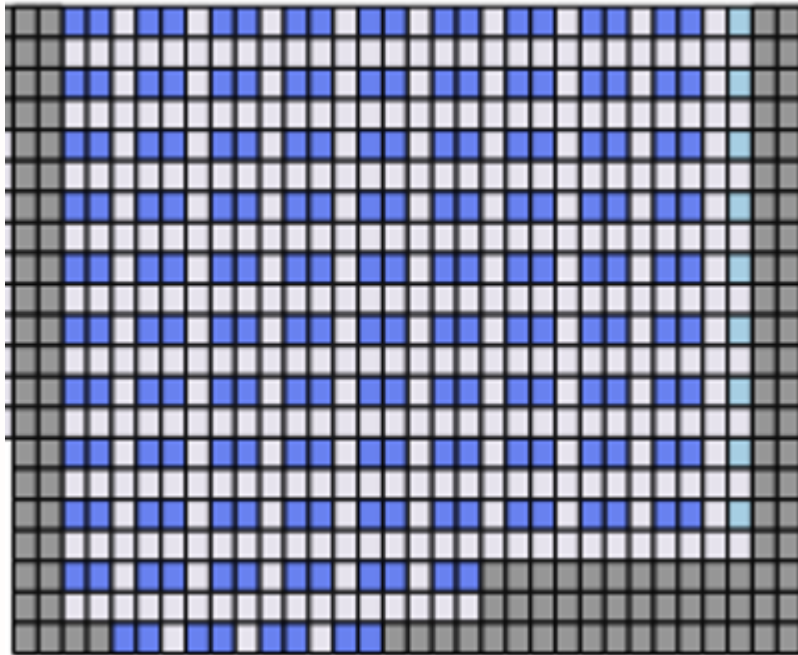
Learning Goals

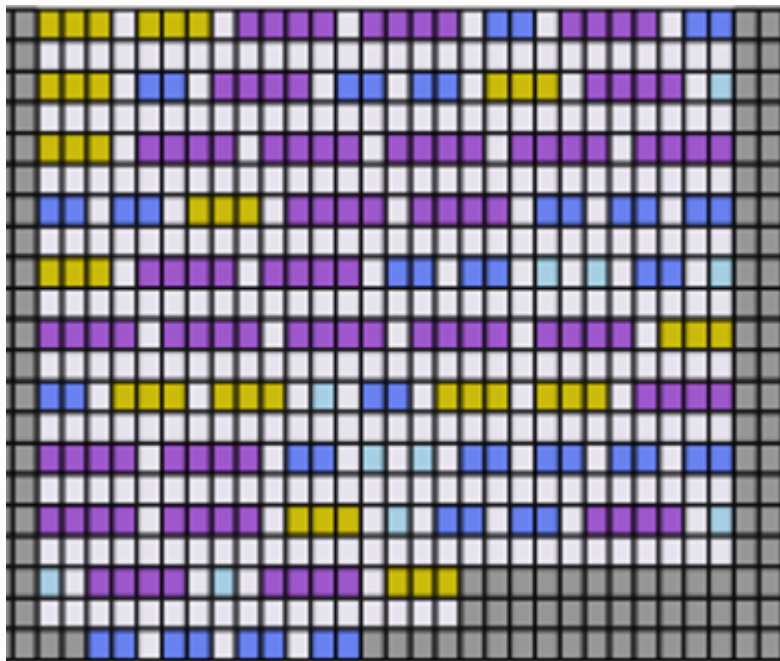
After this lecture, you will be able to:

- **Formulate** the arena seating problem as a binary program
- **Model** group placements with one binary variable per starting seat
- **Enforce** distancing rules with rectangle covering constraints
- **Distinguish** operational, tactical, and strategic seating decisions

Problem Structure

Example: Two different plans





Different Approaches Possible

1. Operational
2. Tactical
3. Strategic

...

Question: **What are these approaches in general and how do they relate to arena seating?**

Operational

- **Short-term**, day-to-day decisions
- Focused on immediate execution

...

Question: **What is an example of this approach?**

...

- Given **tomorrow's demand** of differently sized groups
- Score groups (importance, sponsors, VIP, season ticket,...)
- Assigning specific seats for **tomorrow's event**

Tactical

- **Medium-term** planning (weeks to months)
- Bridges operational and strategic levels

...

Question: **What is an example of this approach?**

...

- Given distribution of **expected demand** for groups
- Score groups (importance, sponsors, VIP, season ticket,...)
- Plan seating arrangements for an **upcoming season**

Strategic

- Long-term planning (months to years)
- Focus on overall goals and policies

...

Question: **What is an example of this approach?**

...

- Design one **fixed layout** that works well across different demand scenarios
- Maximize the overall **space utilization**
- Sell the resulting layout as a standard product on the market

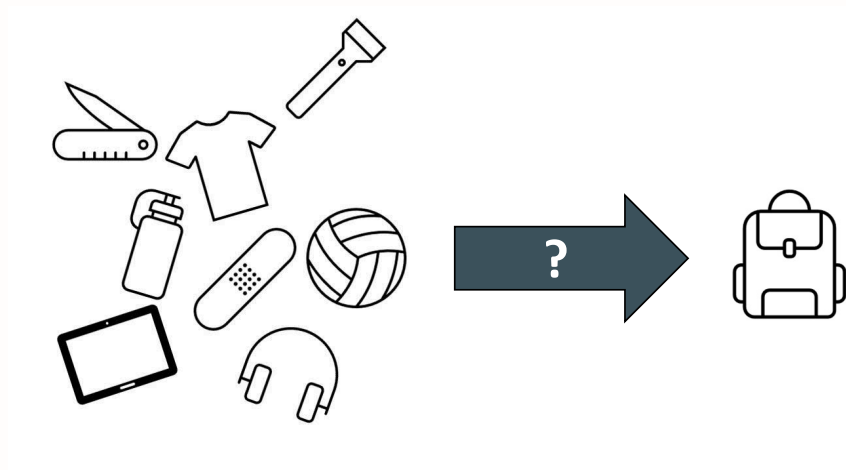
Main Question

Task: **Fill the seating area given distancing regulations and venue-specific constraints.**

Question: **Any ideas on how to approach this?**

Knapsack

Knapsack Problem



- Standard model in Operations Research
- **Select items** from a pool under **capacity constraints**

Knapsack Problem in 2D

	c1	c2	c3	c4	c5	c6	c7	c8	c9	c10	c11	c12	c13	c14	c15	c16	c17	c18	c19	c20	c21	c22	c23	c24	c25	c26	c27	c28	c29	c30	
r1	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	12	12
r2	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	12	12
r3	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r4	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r6	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r7	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r8	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r9	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r10	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r11	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r12	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r13	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r14	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	12	12
r15	1	1	1		9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9		3	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4		
r16	1	1	1		9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	9	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
r17	1	1	1		10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
r18	1	1	1		10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	10	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
r19	1	1	1		11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
r20	1	1	1		11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	11	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2

- Now, items block space in 2D, as illustrated here

Adaptation to Seating

- Horizontal dimension to place groups of participants
- Vertical dimension to ensure enough spacing between rows
- Maximize the “value” of the allocated groups
- Value can be the number of seats or a score

...

Note

Idea behind the model was developed by [Dr. Matthes Koch](#).

Hands-on Exercise

Task: Allocate as many high-value groups as possible.

	c1	c2	c3	c4	c5	c6	c7	c8	c9	c10	
r1											r1
r2											r2
r3											r3
r4											r4
r5											r5
r6											r6
r7											r7
r8											r8
r9											r9
r10											r10
	c1	c2	c3	c4	c5	c6	c7	c8	c9	c10	

Available Groups

Group type	Req. Seats	Score	Available	Allocated	Value
a	1	1	3		
b	2	2	2		
c	2	4	3		
d	4	4	5		
e	4	5	2		
f	6	6	1		
g	6	12	1		
Total					

Seating Constraints

- 1 empty seat **between** groups
- 1 empty seat **front-to-back**
- 1 empty seat **diagonally**
- Only **2 groups per row** are allowed
- Grey seats represent **obstacles**

...

You have 5 minutes to find a solution.

Question: **What is your total score?**

Which Groups Did You Pick First?

Question: **How valuable is each group per seat?**

...

- Groups c and g yield 2 points per seat
- Group e yields 1.25 points, all other groups exactly 1
- Grabbing the “densest” groups first is a **greedy strategy**

...

Note

Placing all groups would require 53 seats and yield 67 points — but the blocked seats and the distancing rules make this impossible.

How Good Is Your Plan?

Question: **What is the best possible score?**

...

- The optimal seating plan reaches 52 points

- Manual plans usually fall a few points short
- Greedy choices are a good start, but **combining** them optimally is hard

...

Tip

In the tutorial, we will model exactly this seating area and let the solver find the optimal plan **within seconds**.

Model Formulation

Sets?

Question: **What could be the sets?**

...

- $\mathcal{G}$ - Set of groups, indexed by g
- $\mathcal{R}$ - Set of rows, indexed by r
- $\mathcal{C}$ - Set of columns, indexed by c
- $\mathcal{C}_{g,r}$ - Available seats of row r for group g , indexed by c

...

Note

$\mathcal{C}_{g,r}$ contains only **feasible starting seats**: a seat c belongs to it only if the entire group g fits into row r from seat c onward without crossing a blocked seat or the end of the row. This is why the set depends on both g and r .

Parameters?

Question: **What could be possible parameters?**

...

- p_r - Maximal number of groups allowed in one row r
- d_g - Required seats of a group g in a row
- h - Safety distance between groups sitting next to each other
- b - Vertical safety distance between groups
- v_g - Value of an allocation of the group g

Variables and Objective

Decision Variable?

! Our goal is to:

Maximize the group values by filling the seating area given distancing regulations between groups and venue-specific constraints.

💡 Tip

Each group is represented by **one binary variable**. We don't need to block each seat explicitly with a binary variable! The sets $\mathcal{C}_{g,r}$ make this possible, as variables only exist where the **whole group** actually fits.

Decision Variable

i We need the following sets:

- All the groups, $g \in \mathcal{G}$
- All the rows, $r \in \mathcal{R}$
- All the columns, $c \in \mathcal{C}$

Question: **What could be our decision variable?**

...

- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if **first left seat** of g is assigned to r in c , else 0

Objective Function?

! Our main objective is to:

Maximize the group values by filling the seating area given distancing regulations between groups and venue-specific constraints.

...

Question: **How again are groups allocated?**

...

- By the allocation of the **first left seat** of a group to a row and column in the seating area

Objective Function

i We need the following parameters and variables:

- v_g - Value of an allocation of the group g
- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if **first left seat** of g is assigned to r in c , else 0

...

Question: **What could be our objective function?**

...

$$\text{Maximize } \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}} v_g \times X_{g,r,c}$$

Constraints

Necessary Constraints

Question: **What constraints do we need?**

...

- Assign **each group only once**
- Restrict the **number of groups in each row**
- Ensure the **horizontal social distance**
- Keep the **vertical social distance**

Assign Each Group Only Once?

! The goal of this constraint is to:

Ensure that each group is allocated only once in the entire seating area.

...

i We need the following:

- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if first left seat of g is assigned to r in c , else 0
- $\mathcal{G}$ - Set of groups, indexed by g
- $\mathcal{R}$ - Set of rows, indexed by r
- $\mathcal{C}_{g,r}$ - Set of columns of row r for group g , indexed by c

Assign Each Group Only Once

Question: **What could be the constraint?**

...

$$\sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}} X_{g,r,c} \leq 1 \quad \forall g \in \mathcal{G}$$

...

i Note

This “set packing” constraint ensures that a group is only **assigned once**.

Restrict Groups Per Row?

! The goal of this constraint is to:

Ensure that the number of groups in each row does not exceed the maximum allowed number of groups.

...

i We need the following:

- p_r - Maximal number of groups allowed in one row r
- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if first left seat of g is assigned to r in c , else 0

Restrict Groups Per Row

Question: **What could be the constraint?**

...

$$\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}} X_{g,r,c} \leq p_r \quad \forall r \in \mathcal{R}$$

...

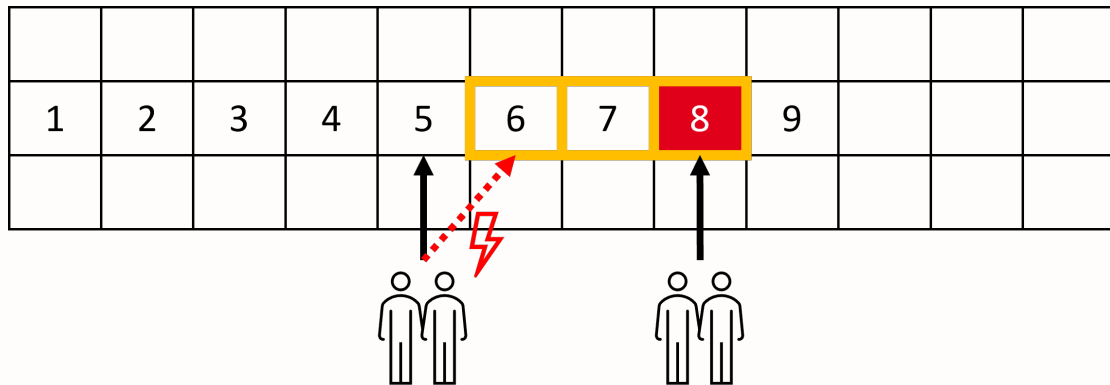
i Note

We want to place as **many highly scoring groups as possible**, but people need to move to buy drinks or use the restroom. Depending on the venue, they should **not cross other groups** in the **same row**.

The last two constraints are somewhat tricky!

Social Distance Implementation

Central Idea



...

Tip

Assume **one seat between groups must be kept empty**. If one group takes seat 8, it uses seats 8 and 9. We thus **cannot allocate** another group of size 2 to seats 6, 7 or 8.

Horizontal Social Distance?

Question: **Any ideas how to implement this?**

...

! The goal of this constraint is to:

Ensure that the horizontal social distance is maintained between groups.

...

i We need the following:

- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if first left seat of g is assigned to r in c , else 0
- d_g - Required seats of group g in a row
- h - Safety distance between groups sitting next to each other

Horizontal Social Distance

As the constraint is based on a rather complex set, you don't have to find it on your own.

...

$$\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{\tilde{c} \in \tilde{\mathcal{C}}_{g,c}} X_{g,r,\tilde{c}} \leq 1 \quad \forall r \in \mathcal{R}, c \in \mathcal{C}$$

...

Note

At first glance, this constraint looks rather easy, but it is not - it is based on the set $\tilde{\mathcal{C}}_{g,c}$, a set not yet defined in the lecture.

The Social Distancing Set

$$\tilde{\mathcal{C}}_{g,c} = \{\tilde{c} \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r} \mid c - d_g + 1 - h \leq \tilde{c} \leq c\}$$

...

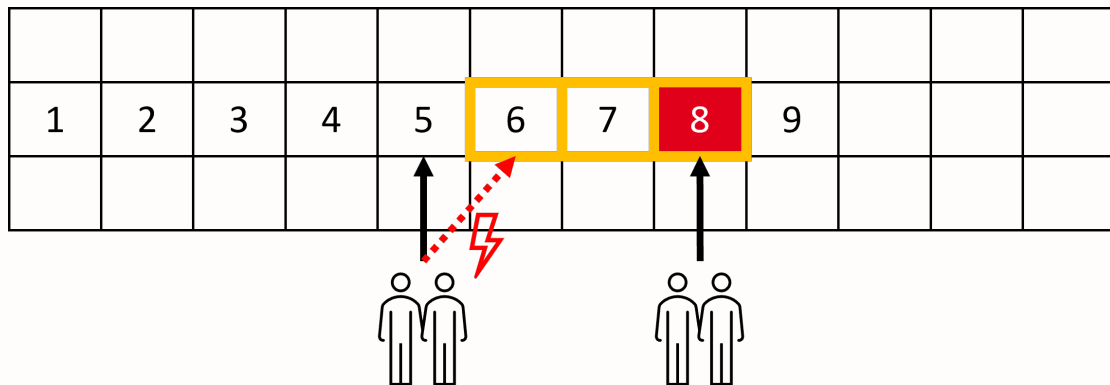
Remember:

- d_g - Required seats of group g in a row
- h - Safety distance between groups sitting next to each other
- $\mathcal{C}_{g,r}$ - Feasible starting seats, as variables only exist for these seats (the row r follows from the constraint)

...

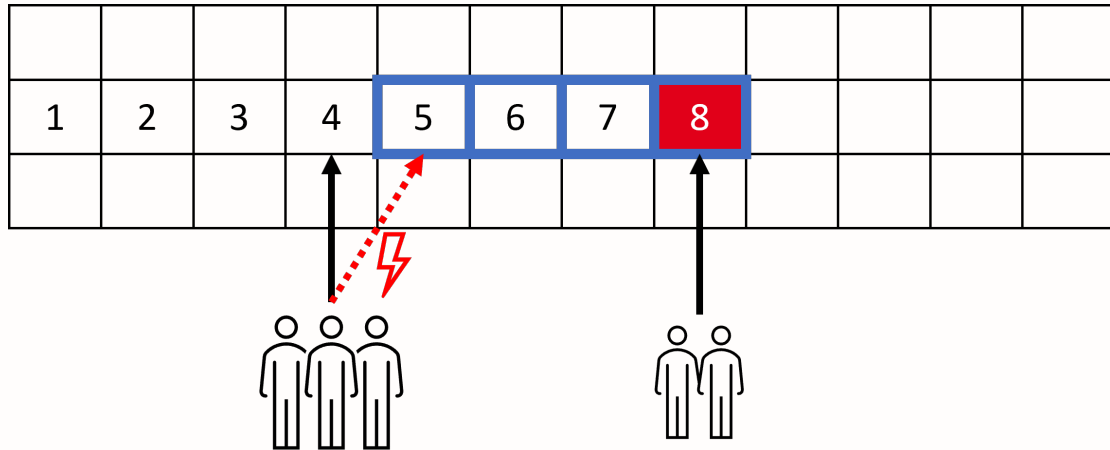
Question: Can anybody explain the set?

Example: Two Groups



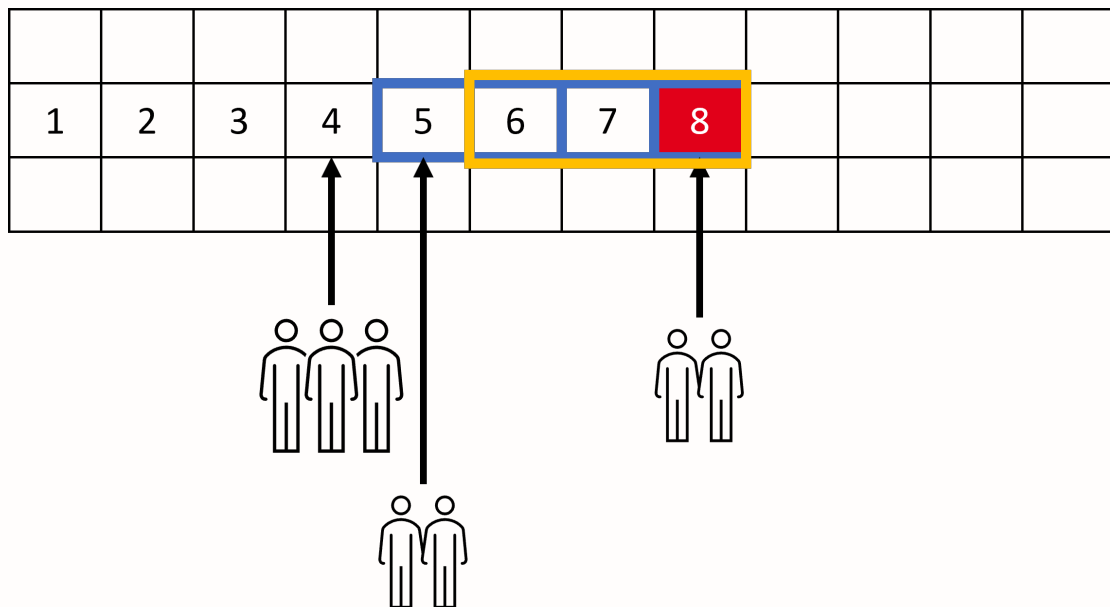
$$\underbrace{X_{1,2,6} + X_{1,2,7} + X_{1,2,8}}_{g=1} + \underbrace{X_{2,2,6} + X_{2,2,7} + X_{2,2,8}}_{g=2} \leq 1 \quad (r = 2, c = 8)$$

Example: Different Group Sizes



$$\underbrace{X_{1,2,6} + X_{1,2,7} + X_{1,2,8}}_{g=1} + \underbrace{X_{2,2,5} + X_{2,2,6} + X_{2,2,7} + X_{2,2,8}}_{g=2} \leq 1 \quad (r=2, c=8)$$

Example: Three Groups



$$\underbrace{X_{1,2,6} + X_{1,2,7} + X_{1,2,8}}_{g=1} + \underbrace{X_{2,2,6} + X_{2,2,7} + X_{2,2,8}}_{g=2} + \underbrace{X_{3,2,5} + X_{3,2,6} + X_{3,2,7} + X_{3,2,8}}_{g=3} \leq 1 \quad (r=2, c=8)$$

Do you see
the pattern?

Vertical Social Distance?

! The goal of this constraint is to:

Ensure that the vertical social distance is maintained between groups.

...

i We need the following:

- b - Vertical safety distance between groups
- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if first left seat of g is assigned to r in c , else 0

Vertical Social Distance

Question: **What could be the constraint?**

...

💡 Tip

It is an extension of the horizontal social distance constraint we used before, but now we **block a rectangular area** instead of a single row.

...

$$\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{\tilde{r} \in \tilde{\mathcal{R}}_r} \sum_{\tilde{c} \in \tilde{\mathcal{C}}_{g,c}} X_{g,\tilde{r},\tilde{c}} \leq 1 \quad \forall r \in \mathcal{R}, c \in \mathcal{C}$$

Vertical Distance Set

Question: **What could be the set?**

...

$$\tilde{\mathcal{R}}_r = \{\tilde{r} \in \mathcal{R} \mid r - b \leq \tilde{r} \leq r\}$$

...

i Note

Remember:

- b - Vertical safety distance between groups
- $X_{g,r,c}$ - 1, if first left seat of g is assigned to r in c , else 0

...

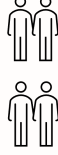
Let's look at an example.

Example: Two Groups

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8		

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8		

Example placement



1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8		

- Yellow seats are **blocked by the group** in row 3 and column 8
- Blue allocations are possible (if second group has **size 2**)

Arena Seating Problem

$$\text{Maximize } \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}} v_g \times X_{g,r,c}$$

subject to:

$$\sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}} X_{g,r,c} \leq 1 \quad \forall g \in \mathcal{G}$$

$$\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}} X_{g,r,c} \leq p_r \quad \forall r \in \mathcal{R}$$

$$\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \sum_{\tilde{r} \in \tilde{\mathcal{R}}_r} \sum_{\tilde{c} \in \tilde{\mathcal{C}}_{g,\tilde{r}}} X_{g,\tilde{r},\tilde{c}} \leq 1 \quad \forall r \in \mathcal{R}, c \in \mathcal{C}$$

$$X_{g,r,c} \in \{0, 1\} \quad \forall g \in \mathcal{G}, r \in \mathcal{R}, c \in \mathcal{C}_{g,r}$$

Where Did the Horizontal Constraint Go?

Question: **Why does the model contain only three constraints?**

...

- The vertical set $\tilde{\mathcal{R}}_r$ also contains $\tilde{r} = r$, the **row itself**
- For $\tilde{r} = r$, the rectangle constraint is **exactly** the horizontal one

...

Note

The rectangle constraint **subsumes** the horizontal social distance constraint. We can thus drop the horizontal constraint without losing anything.

Model Characteristics

Characteristics

Questions: **On model characteristics**

- Is the model formulation linear/ non-linear?
- What kind of variable domains do we have?

...

Note

The model is **linear**, as the objective and all constraints are weighted sums of the variables. All variables are **binary**, making it a pure binary program.

Model Assumptions

Questions: **On model assumptions**

- What assumptions have we made?
- Is our approach strategic or tactical/operational?
- Have we considered all social distancing constraints?
- What about aisle seats?
- Can you think of any other real-world constraints?

Implementation and Impact

Arena Seating Optimization

Case study VfL Osnabrück

- Relegation Return Match in 2021
- 241 additional seats allocated (+12 percent)
- Compliance with all distancing requirements
- Approval from authorities

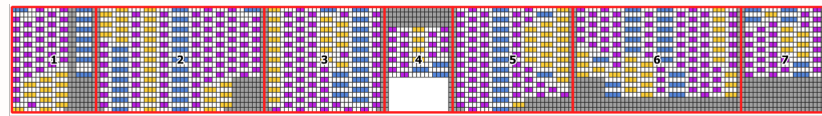
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Important

Estimated additional revenue of **8,435 EUR** for one match.

Seating Plan

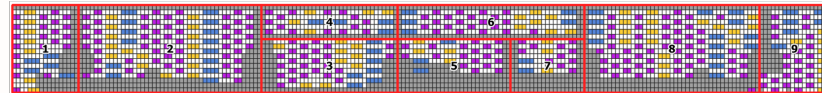
Block	Plätze		
	Verfügbar	Belegt	Belegt %
Nord 1	349	135	38.7%
Nord 2	788	290	36.8%
Nord 3	586	217	37.0%
Nord 4	150	56	37.3%
Nord 5	549	204	37.2%
Nord 6	692	254	36.7%
Nord 7	266	99	37.2%
Nord Gesamt	3380	1255	37.1%
Süd 1	214	83	38.8%
Süd 2	587	218	37.1%
Süd 3	281	105	37.4%
Süd 4	165	61	37.0%
Süd 5	153	60	39.2%
Süd 6	225	83	36.9%
Süd 7	105	39	37.1%
Süd 8	576	213	37.0%
Süd 9	251	96	38.2%
Süd Gesamt	2557	958	37.5%
Nord+Süd Gesamt	5937	2213	37.3%



Nordtribüne



Südtribüne



Modellrechnung Bremer Brücke

Related Work

- The model of this lecture is published in U. Dkaidik and M. Koch [1]

...

Similar studies have been conducted globally:

- Music Hall Eindhoven: D. Blom, R. Pendavingh, and F. Spieksma [2]
- US College-level venues, e.g. Football, Basketball, Hockey
- Safe Seating Solutions platform
- General 2D-Knapsack applications

Conclusion

Optimization Benefits

- Optimization enables **rapid generation and evaluation**
- We can easily adapt to **various distancing requirements**:
 - Horizontal and vertical spacing between groups
 - Groups per row limits
 - Aisle seat restrictions
 - Group size constraints
 - Multi-row group allocation

Wrap Up

- Revenue optimization through applied optimization
- **Increased participant capacity** vs basic approaches
- Flexible adaptation to **various distancing requirements**
- Can be adapted easily to **any seating requirements**

...

i And that's it for today's lecture!

We now have covered the arena seating problem based on a real-world application and are ready to start solving the corresponding tasks in the upcoming tutorial.

Questions?

Literature

Literature

- Press coverage of the VfL Osnabrück case: [University of Hamburg newsroom](#) (in German)

For more interesting literature to learn more about Julia, take a look at the [literature list](#) of this course.

Bibliography

- [1] U. Dkaidik and M. Koch, "Arena Seat Planning Under Distancing Rules," *Operations Research Proceedings 2024*. Springer, Cham, pp. 82–88, 2025. doi: [10.1007/978-3-031-92575-7_12](#).
- [2] D. Blom, R. Pendavingh, and F. Spieksma, "Filling a Theater During the COVID-19 Pandemic," *INFORMS Journal on Applied Analytics*, vol. 52, no. 6, pp. 473–484, 2022, doi: [10.1287/inte.2021.1104](#).